

Human Experience



Realization.
Awareness.
Reflection.



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iiyak ka rin sa huli

Creative Nonfiction by Tasha Montoya

When I was growing up, my mom would always tell me never to laugh too hard, never to smile too much, never to be too happy. Because, in an instant, things can always change. The happier you are, the greedier you become with this feeling and the more prone you are to fail. In our family, this was the concept of karma; that, your future would be shaped by how extreme your emotions are in the present. When you laugh too hard or too much, you'll always end up in tears.

Me and my mom had always been fond of superstitious beliefs. Whether it was the mornings we shared checking the horoscopes section on newspapers or the matching evil eyes we keep in our wallets, she had always laughed at how similar we were in looking for something bigger to believe in. Then, as I reached high school, I realized how her silly sayings and lectures had stemmed in the concept of a real and practiced belief: karma. In Buddhist religion, karma describes how our intentions of our actions shaped the consequences we would achieve because of it. To my mom, and many other Filipinos, the concept of karma stemmed from a belief in the balance of life – specifically, that any excessive joy or happiness attracts negative emotions and misfortune to restore the scales. But to me, as I had adapted from these various understandings, karma was the fear that if I don't do something good, something bad would happen to me – I would end up in tears.

Like any other child hoping to clean up the corners of their well-rounded life in the hopes of making their parents proud, I had turned to community service. From fourth grade to high school graduation, I gave up Saturdays to spend early-mornings in outreaches at orphanages in Manila, tree plantings in the mountains, and Aeta communities in Tarlac. Though I had found genuine passion for service, and regarded these times as where I had truly found who I was and wanted to become, I knew that there was a small part of me that had hoped I was balancing the scales. I thought that exposing myself to harsh realities and advocating for justice was the bargain I had made with

karma to limit misfortune to those of others, ones that I could try and fix. I was doing something objectively good, with the spark of hope that I would receive good in return.

And for a while, it had worked. As I prepared to move up into my last two years of high school, I was presented with an opportunity I could have never imagined, Ateneo Senior High School. I moved to my (and more importantly, my parents') dream school and despite being racked with guilt of leaving my childhood friends and the fear of moving forward, my trust in karma had allowed me to experience a lifetime of adventure and love. In the short time before graduation, I had found a new passion for journalism – what would end up as my college course, a found family of people who I could wholeheartedly rely on, achievements I never knew I could reach, and unexpectedly finding the person who I thought was my person. And though these all came as earned blessings with years of hard work behind them, I can't lie to say that there was no trace of luck in everything I received. In fact, many of my friends knew me to always preach "everything in the right time" or, karma will reward you. So, concluding those years, I had walked the stage in a blue toga to cross Katipunan, never realizing I had laughed too hard until it was too late.

This part of the story remains cliché. Everyone finds college hard – whether in academics, culture shocks, or new friends. But to me, there was that nagging feeling of something impending, I just couldn't place what. Soon enough, the foundation of what my current life was built on, the home I had built as a sanctuary, started to succumb to this darkness and slowly started to fade away.

First was my friends. I mean, but who could really blame them? As the only person from all friend groups to stray away from the blue eagle path into college, I knew my life would be misaligned with theirs. For instance, they had no classes on Wednesdays while I had a full day, they had a holistically built schedule of 8 am to 4 pm classes while I was in school at all random hours, and so much more. Despite how heavy the burden of adjustment was, I knew it was my own choice to leave them and this guilt drove me to do more for them, to be the one always available. I was the first, sometimes only, person to message in group chats and the only one asking to

hang out. Meanwhile, they started to build a life where answering a message was too time-consuming to fathom, they had joined the organizations I dreamed of while judging me for the unfamiliarity of mine, and made friends that knew each other while I grasped at straws to remember their names. I realized that stopped myself from creating a full life here, because I always left a space for them, something they couldn't seem to return as a favor.

Next, was my course. Like every other college story you hear about being placed in a prestigious university where you realize you are in a room full of the best, you realize how much catching up you have to do, not to get ahead but to just not fall behind. In every 3-hour major I spent in my college, I had heard my peers' stories of their high school lives dedicated to campus journalism, their distinguished home publications, and their year-after-year trips to National Schools Press Conference (NSPC), while I had only picked up a pen in the past two years. So, no matter how hard I tried to work and prove that high school was not the peak of my career, I knew I was only average in comparison. And then came my coursemates; as if the humility the course load was giving me wasn't enough, my coursemates decided to reinforce my displacement in this program. Understanding the responsibility and accountability of being well-off and still choosing to go to UP, I hadn't realized that "burgis" was all I would ever come to be known as. I was being watched for every step I was taking and being judged accordingly. Though I had found a small group of people that I could let my guard down with, I knew that some part of them thought the same as the rest, so I decided to keep to myself. At that point, it was physically impossible to find my place when people were constantly pushing me out. And as the year ended with our college parangal, I watched from afar realizing I would never walk the stage again, not because I hadn't earned it, but because I had been told not to celebrate it.

When the world leaves you out in the cold, you go to the person that feels like home, and for a long time I thought I knew who that was. He had been with me through every last of high school and almost every first of college, and when we separated our lives into blue and maroon, we knew it wouldn't be easy. I just didn't realize it wouldn't be so hard that staying wouldn't feel like an option. When you've built your life around a person that's not yourself – adjusting to his schedule, workload, and exams, sacrificing the time you

spend with your own friends, and forgetting that there was a version of you that wasn't made for him – the abundance of love you once had slowly begins to transform into resentment. I felt like I was begging for him to give me love, whether that was in the time we spent together squeezed into his exams, the respect he could give for what I was doing in college, or the presence of a person to be there for me when I most needed. And when I had asked, and had been told that I was being unreasonable for asking too much, and had to apologize for overstepping, and had to forgive him for his reaction, and try to ask again to be given only enough to not fight again, I reached a point a point where I realized the easiest thing any of us could do was walk away.

I had reached my tears.

No matter how many times I had kept choosing to love, and no matter how many objectively good deeds I had committed myself to, this is what karma rewarded me with. So, if I love this much and can still not get anything in return, why love at all?

So I tried to stop myself and started to love in enclosed spaces, a love that's controlled. But I also realized, that's not what love is or is supposed to be.

My mom had always said never to laugh too hard or I'll cry, and maybe that's what I did. Maybe I let myself love too hard and expect too much, and it caught up to me. Cosmic karma, a debt I was repaying in full. And I keep asking, what did I gain?

Love and life is not about gaining, it's about experiencing – **love is living**. Crying, losing, bad outcomes of good deeds, these experiences and emotions are all part of what makes us human; this mortal karma is not something I could reverse, run away from, or stop. Throughout all that I've lost, I learned that each person I've loved and each experience of loving has been a reflection of who I am as a person. And that person isn't too bad.

Laugh harder, love louder, and don't be afraid to cry after.

The Coolest Person in the World

Creative Nonfiction by Jai de Luna

When I was a child, I thought he was the coolest person in the world. I was like his yellow chamois cloth—I absorbed everything about him: his personality, his hobbies, his humor, even the way he carried himself.

One of my earliest memories is lying on the bottom bunk where he slept while we watched *Gintama* on the computer beside his bed. I also remember watching him play *Heroes of Newerth*. One time, he suddenly had to take a call and asked me to play for him for a while. The moment I figured out how to move the character, the chatbox was already flooded with “noob” and “bano.” I was so embarrassed that I could barely look at him afterward.

As I grew older, I followed him in quieter ways like a mini-him. I kept watching anime on my own and eventually caught up to *Gintama*, *Hunter · Hunter*, and *One Piece* because he loved them first. I got into games too—late nights on *VALORANT*, grinding ranks in *Mobile Legends*, exploring every corner of *Genshin Impact*. I even finished *Elden Ring* because I knew he would have been impressed that I did.

In college, people often ask why I became a chemical engineer. I usually joke and say it was for the money, but the truth is simpler than that. He was a civil engineer, and he was the best at it. At one point, I told him I wanted to study civil engineering too, but he flat out told me no. Jokingly, he said I should stop copying him and take a different course instead. He teased me constantly even though I usually answered with silence and awkward laughs. Somehow, we still understood each other perfectly. He was like the best friend I never had to force conversation with. He was the happiest and most carefree man I knew.

Looking back now, I realize how much of his love always appeared in his actions.

He bought me new white shoes after noticing the old pairs he had given me were already ruined beyond recognition. He bought me a new gaming laptop after learning that my old one had literally exploded—ironically, he gave it to me on his own birthday. That’s just how selfless he is. For my birthday, he organized a small celebration with a huge feast on a rooftop overlooking the beautiful skyline in Rockwell Center. I later found out from his girlfriend that he even wanted to buy me those trending ballet shoes because he always caught me staring at them. I developed impossibly high standards for men as he had already set it so high.

And he *always* had my back.

During the final year of the COVID-19 pandemic, my mental state deteriorated to the point where intrusive thoughts became overwhelming, and I began to lose control of myself in ways I couldn’t resist. When my sister told him over the phone, I could hear the panic in his voice through the loudspeaker—a tone so unlike his usual calm, steady warmth that it startled me. It was as though something inside him had broken loose; he dropped everything and rushed out of his apartment without a word. Anxiety overtook him as he grabbed his car keys and stepped on the gas pedal. What should have been an hour-long drive became thirty minutes despite the rush hour traffic. His heartbeat might as well have been louder than his engine.

When he finally walked through the door, it felt as though a wave of clarity and stillness washed over me. Seeing his grief-stricken face made me realize I never wanted him to carry that kind of distress because of me. The moment he reached for my hand felt like salvation. I noticed then that, in his haste, he had forgotten to take his rubber shoes off before entering the house. He gently towel-dried my hair, combed it with care, and wrapped my drenched self in a dry towel. Then he handed me clean clothes and brought me to his car so we could talk without anyone else hearing.

He already knew I was not like that. Something must have pushed me far beyond my limits. I poured my heart out and tried to explain everything, but my tears kept cutting me off. My voice was breaking—not because of the pain I had accumulated for years, but because of his quiet, genuine kindness that reached me so gently it almost hurt. It feels selfish to admit, but part of me

was comforted by how deeply he seemed affected—how much it meant to him that I was hurting.

I think he gave me all his life that day. But I didn't get to give it back.

I received the news of his death four years after that incident, my last semester in university. For thirty straight minutes, all I could do was cry. It felt like the world had collapsed, like everything familiar had suddenly become unrecognizable. But I was the last one to know. At first it felt unfair, but I wanted to believe that at the end, he still wanted to protect me from the overwhelming grief. That his final act of protection was that his last message was sent to a group chat I wasn't part of. Maybe my family also wanted to give me three extra hours to live in a world where he was still alive.

All I ever wanted was to be like him. Which made me want to follow where he went. Questions replayed endlessly in my head. Was he scared? Was he crying? Was he hungry? Did he feel free? How did I not see this coming? Could I have done anything?

His girlfriend told me that I was the last thing they talked about. He had been so excited to watch me graduate in three months. So I have to. He was proud of me. He had even planned to buy me a brand-new gaming laptop as a graduation gift. That I was his favorite. That he felt like I was growing up to be like him.

I don't need it now. I just need him to know that I love him so dearly. The worst part is that I never told him "I love you". So now all that love has nowhere to go.

For a month, I have been running from the grief—ignoring it, isolating myself, wanting to disappear from everything and everyone. I wanted to abandon every responsibility and simply exist. Hell, I don't even think I've made it past the first stage of grief yet.

Grief—I don't think it ever truly leaves a person. It just changes shape. Sometimes it becomes silence. Sometimes anger. Sometimes it appears in dreams that feel so real that waking up feels like losing them all over again. Sometimes it's crying over the last restaurant he took me to, or the ice cream place we would

always go to on Sundays. Sometimes it's seeing traces of him everywhere, even in things that only faintly resemble a memory. I found myself fixating on anything that reminded me of him, no matter how small or uncertain the connection was. Sometimes it's looking at strangers laughing together and feeling angry at them for being happy. It is irrational, selfish even, but grief has a way of making the entire world feel offensive for continuing to move normally.

I didn't really know how to cope—I only learned how to get through each unbearable day. I would either sleep the entire day or not sleep at all. I talked to no one. No one could help with the pain I was in anyway, and I would only make them uncomfortable with something they couldn't hold. Besides, every other relationship in my life began to feel insignificant compared to the one I had already lost. Apathy slowly became routine. Even the most basic daily tasks turned into heavy, exhausting chores I had to push myself through rather than live. I tried everything to distract myself—endless scrolling, chemical engineering design sheets, music loud enough to drown my thoughts—but even distraction came with guilt, as if looking away for even a moment meant I was betraying something. I felt like I wasn't supposed to forget. Not even briefly. Not him. The pain never truly stopped. I just learned how to carry it.

And still, morning comes anyway. Time does not stop for anyone. The world keeps spinning, indifferent and unchanged. And people will eventually stop checking in.

And so, it's now up to me to live the life he would have wanted to live until the end—to carry him with me in the decisions I make, in the way I continue forward. That's what I tell myself he would want. But I don't know.

I just want my *big brother* back.

life360

Creative Nonfiction by Nicole Morales

When the app Life360 started becoming popular, I did not see the point of having to download it. My classmates, barkadas, teammates, and parents started creating circles that I joined out of the fear of missing out. It was weird having to reveal my location to multiple people at all times so I never really opened the app.

But as our circles spent more time with each other, time apart felt emptier and lonelier. So we checked the maps on our phones and tried to find where our tiny faces were situated. If we're close enough then that means we won't have dinner alone, if not then pressing the ❤️ Love ya ! button on the app will suffice.

Finally having a bedroom — in my own condo unit at that — after sixteen years of sharing one with my parents felt like a scene straight out of Ferris Bueller's Day Off. I could do everything I put my mind to without having to think of who was watching. The only difference is, I had months off instead of a day.

All throughout senior high, it was simple. I had a routine of going to school, eating with my friends, and attending training. My parents knew about this routine, so as long as they saw the same places at certain times on Life360, they didn't have to ask.

But life starts after high school. After two years of riding my friend's pick-up truck to go to Paeng's Bowling and Billiards in Eastwood every other day before training, I was now riding the back of motorcycles. It was so fast and convenient that I had to look for something to fill my day with. My normal schedule of training twice a week after school was not enough so I accepted gigs and started becoming a styling intern.

In my internship I would just show up to the set, where my boss would ask

“why are you so early?” even though I had arrived exactly at call time. I would steam racks of clothes and dress the models for the shoot. My boss would make me take pictures of a model, one where they’re wearing a pink polo and another where the polo is in a slightly darker hue of pink just to ask the director which would look better on camera. I was working in commercial production.

I would prepare three identical copies of the same shirt because our job was to dress people like pedestrians, only within the color palette of the company we’re shooting for.

As a child, I was always fascinated by commercials. The actors always reacted to the food they were eating as if it would physically hurt if their mouth weren’t open wide enough when they took a bite. But it was their clothes I never really cared for. They always wore the most basic of things that even I won’t dare to leave the house in. Now that I’m here, I always get the itch to dress them differently, though there’s never much I can do because I still have to follow what my boss tells me. This however, is much better than staying trapped in my one bedroom unit where I was supposed to be.

Since my usual spots moved farther and farther from Katipunan Avenue, my ‘Morales Family’ circle became active again. All of the application features from Drive Report to Place Notifications were enabled to make sure that I was at the right place at the right time. The second my parents notice I don’t follow my schedule, they ring my phone until I answer. Eventually, I stopped picking up the phone. It wasn’t how I wanted to live. I was supposed to wander the city freely without someone tracking my every move through their cellphone screen. So I ignored all the messages and calls from the people that were 16 kilometers away from me because they weren’t near the destination I aimed to be at. My days were filled with rehearsals at the studio, photoshoots with models, and occasional dinners with friends. I was slowly entering the circle of the accomplished people whom I idolized.

I went to work dressed like them, got the same Starbucks order as them, and constructed my sentences the same way as them, like I could also call myself a full-time creative. But as I moved one place to another trying to

follow the schedule I arranged for myself I realized that I was actually alone. In the in-betweens of my routine, no one is really there to help me, but myself. These people I spent my days with were only encounters, and in their eyes, I was just the young passionate intern of the season.

Even then, I persisted, because I knew that I could find my own way. Besides, all of the people claiming to guide me through life had only ever told me what they wanted me to do. There was freedom to think and freedom to speak, but never freedom to create. How could I call myself an artist when there are people using surveillance systems all over my life checking if I am following their rules.

So I deleted the app that has been holding me captive and ran. My guardians and bosses were surely looking for me and might even be wondering what I could possibly do now that I was alone. They forgot that I had a disgusting amount of faith in myself. Among all the calls I got after running, one stood out. Someone was asking for styling advice under my name, and I was confused about what they needed me to do.

“You can do whatever you want, I trust your vision,” the caller said.

I immediately opened my suitcase and packed the clothes collecting dust in my closet, for I was about to play dress-up with a much bigger playground. With an unfamiliar lightness in my body, I danced and danced until I could no longer recognize the roads my newly worn bejeweled shoes had stepped on.

Social Rehearsal

Poetry by Aly Sandoval

Act 1: Entering the Room

I arrive early, the halls still silent in the morning light
My spine straightens as I step inside the room,
Borrowing the posture of the girl I just passed by

I scan the room for familiar faces
Before choosing a seat by the door
Where no one turns to look for long
But near enough to hear every voice clearly

I watch as people arrive one after another
Greeting according to expression
Bright and cheerful for one, mellow and quiet for the next
Until talking feels like I'm reflecting whoever I'm facing

Act 2: In the Discussion

The clicks of keyboards and the scratch of pens fill the room
Then comes the question I dread the most, one I never answer first
“What do you think of this?”

I try to start a sentence in my head
then erase it when someone else speaks
I take in the nodding heads, the adjectives said with certainty
Reshaping my answer before it could be heard

And when I finally speak, I follow their rhythm
slightly delayed, slightly adjusted
Until I forget where my words began
and where they just become echoes of what's already been said

Act 3: After the Class

I leave before most people,

The sound of chairs scraping the floor filling the corridor

As my own footsteps mix into those around me

At home, I fill the silence quickly

Shuffled music in one ear, assignments spread across the desk

Anything with direction

Anything that keeps my hands moving

I stay busy so my mind doesn't wander

I don't speak, not even to myself

Not when there's no one to adjust to,

Not when there is nothing left to reflect.

A Mother's Guide to Safety

Poetry by Aly Sandoval

Rule Number One:

Before leaving, check your reflection at least once
Not to admire, but to confirm you look like someone
Who knows where she is going

Rule Number Two:

Hold your keys between your fingers
Not tightly enough to be noticed,
But enough for them to matter when needed

Rule Number Three:

Choose your seats carefully
Back to a wall, eyes to the exits
Comfort can be arranged after you assess what danger might look like
today

Rule Number Four:

Phone brightness up, and awareness even higher
Fake a call when you need to
Don't let it look like you're alone

Rule Number Five:

Keep your steps light and quick,
Like you're expected somewhere else
Not lost. Not wandering. Not available.

Rule Number Six:

If someone follows too closely, do not engage.
Turn to busier streets
Like it was part of your plan

Rule Number Seven:

Know which spaces stay open late

Even if you never plan on entering them

Lights mean witnesses

Rule Number Eight:

Keep your head down to avoid attention

Keep calm

Mind your own business

Rule Number Nine:

Leave like this is normal

Like fear is just another thing you carry

And hope it will be enough

Because it has to be

The Middle

Poetry by Louise Ocampo

I have always loved the middle of things.

Elevators suspended
between floors
Airplanes flying
between the sky and Japan
The layer of peanut butter
pressed between two slices of gardenia

I love the feeling
of almost arriving
Of almost being there

The excitement of packing bags
before the beach trip begins.
The quiet ache
of waiting for your 20th birthday.
The countdown to Christmas
when the night waits
for Jose Mari Chan

I like the moment
when something is close enough
to imagine,
but not close enough
to hold.

The middle has always felt kinder.
Kinder than arrival.
Kinder than endings.
Kinder than the strange silence
after getting everything
you once waited for.

Because while traveling,
every road still leads somewhere.
Every window holds possibility
But arriving,
arriving asks something from you.

So I stay in between:
between buildings,
Between September and December
between two pieces of bread,
between leaving and reaching.

Because somehow
the journey has always felt
more beautiful
than the destination itself

And the chase lets me stay infinite

Red

Poetry by Louise Ocampo

The night starts with the bright red dye of my long hair,
bleeding from the scalp in the cold shower,
chemical runoff leaking into the tiles.

I zip into the only decent scarlet dress,
polyester clawing at my bosoms
a uniform that demands and pays.

Painting on bloody lipstick
cheap and waxy I rescued from the bin
where it is not the only thing for sale.

Long copper nails, carefully filed to shine,
wearing them as quiet blades
in hands I never trained to fight with.

Transforming into the hunter's deer
Beneath the city's bloodshot stare
learning which streets mistake girls like me for prey.

I wait beneath the ruby lamps,
among the neglected,
until a window rolls down to claim me.

The night leaves its mark in my blood
a quiet stain on a mattress where I lay
red and blue lights cutting through the dark.

And still,
I open my eyes for another dawn.

sleepful nights

Poetry by Ines Divinagracia

i dream of being a mime, where i go to my psych appointment
they have to gleam my mental illness via how i act

i dream of being wanted, of the warmth of touch and the
ache of my face from laughing too much

i dream of being an actor, of auditioning for the role of the
tomato-fearing lead but the moment i say the first line, i get
pelted with tomatoes

i dream of being a mother, a belly round and heavy, looking
through baby names and small baby shoes but wondering if i
wanted this at all

i dream of being free, of running through a lush field and
spinning until i'm dizzy and high on relief

i dream of being a heavy sleeper, not waking up to my alarm
and missing 4 gazillion classes so my college adviser tells me
i'm suspended from my dream program

i dream of being a daughter, perfect and kind, funny and
smart, with a back so straight it's almost homophobic

i dream of being better, where i consistently journal, have a
mood tracking app, and walk 10k steps every morning

i dream of being a wife, seeing the Louvre together and
getting told something gross like how i'm the prettiest art in
here while i laugh like a rich aunt

i dream of being dead but i come back from the dead and
everyone yells at me but is secretly glad that i'm back,
maggoty and all

i dream of being a dream. i dream of just being.

a post-grad dilemma

Poetry by Ines Divinagracia

i don't know	if i am able
for this desire to stay versus	the fear of sacrifice means
my self-preservation is	complacency and escape
my guilt, my offense	is my willful ignorance of reality
to turn away is	a privilege upon privileges
another medal presented	another fake degree or lack thereof
fool's gold, tallano gold	another hundred of victims
this unjust and unclean system	is wiped clean from the papers
my nation,	my god,
can prayer rid us of these demons?	is this not hell?
a man goes to be god	in your kingdom
and washes his greedy hands	in pools of blood
remorselessly and uncaringly	there is true evil

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